FOR-AND-AGAINST ESSAYS

How to write one effectively - Part 1

What is a For-and-against essay?

- Also known as „argumentative” essays, these essays are used to report on the positive and negative sides of a particular topic.

- Unlike opinion essays, argumentative essays have a strict FORMAT, CONTENT and STYLE which have to be followed throughout the entire essay.

For-and-against Essay Format

- A For-and-against essay should consist of THREE main parts:
  1. **Introduction**
  2. **Body**
  3. **Conclusion**
- However, a For-and-against Essay always consists of FOUR paragraphs
  1. **Introduction**
  2. **Arguments for**
  3. **Arguments against**
  4. **Conclusion**

Together, these two paragraphs make up the BODY of the essay.

For-and-against Essay Format

- Each individual part of a for-and-against essay also has to consist of several smaller parts.
  - The **Introduction** consists of a *Introductory statement* and a *Thesis statement.*
  - Both the **arguments for** and **arguments against** consist of AT LEAST TWO individual arguments for or against, respectively.
  - The **Conclusion** consists of a *Concluding statement* and a *Personal opinion*

Essay Introduction

- This part of the essay has 2 main functions:
  1. Introduce the reader to the topic in question (*Introductory statement)*
  2. Show the reader that there are two sides to the topic *(Thesis statement)*

- Let's look at an example of this with the following essay topic:

  Some people say school uniforms should be mandatory. Others disagree.

Essay Introduction (Example)

- The title/topic of our essay is the following: *Some people say school uniforms should be mandatory. Others disagree.*

An introductory paragraph may look something like this:

> School uniforms have been present in schools for several decades now. Their popularity has changed over time and in recent year the debate has resurfaced again. While some say that school should pass regulations making school uniforms compulsory for all students, some say that this wouldn't be the right course for the future.

- In this case, the two sentences written in blue are our **introductory statement** (as you can see, it doesn't have to be one single sentence). They tell the reader that the general topic of our essay is school uniforms. The sentence written in red is our **thesis statement**. Its job is to tell the reader that, when it comes to the topic at hand (school uniforms), there are two views – some are for them, some are against them.

- 💡***Quick tip***: If you ever get stuck when trying to think of a good thesis statement, just paraphrase the title of the essay (have it look different, but still saying the same thing).

Essay Conclusion

- Don’t worry! We’ll get to the arguments for and arguments against. Relax! Why aren’t you relaxing?

- A conclusion of a for-and-against essay consists of two parts:
  1. **Concluding statement** – in which we summarise the main talking points from the body of the essay (and basically admit that there really are two sides to the topic in question)
  2. **Personal opinion** – in which we state our opinion on the topic in question. NOTE: this is the ONLY part of the entire essay in which you are allowed to be subjective. Here you can say whether you are „for” the topic, „against” it, maybe somewhere in the middle, or maybe you don’t even care (which is also a valid opinion to have.

  - Let’s look at an example for the same essay topic as before:

Essay Conclusion (example)

- In conlcusion, it is clear that there are both positive sides to school uniforms – *such as developing a sense of community promoting equali*ty – as well as negative sides – *such as the stiffling of student individualism and their questionable effectiveness in battling bullying.* Personally, I think that school uniforms could potentially be a good idea, but that there should be room for students to somehow express themselves through their clothes.

- Here we can easily see where the concluding statement begins, as well as where the personal opinion begins. We use the appropriate linking words or linking phrases (popularly known as *linkers*) to „warn" the reader what will immediatelly follow those linkers. (We'll cover linkers in more detail next week, but you can easily think of some alternatives for these two linkers which are used in the example).
- One other important thing to note is that the arguments you may mention in the conclusion have to be arguments that you've mentioned earlier in the body of the essay, not completely new arguments. Although, it is not absolutely necessary to mention those arguments again. The part of the concluding statemnt written in *italics* can be left out and it would still be a good concluding statement.

The Essay Body (Arguments for/against)

- Today we'll only cover the basics of writing the body of an essay, and go into more detail on how to choose, write and refine your arguments next week.

- The main rules/guidelines for writing the body of the essay (or the main TWO paragraphs are):

  1. You need to have the same number of arguments for and arguments against (2 of each, 3 of each…)
  2. You need at least 2 of each arguments (for a minimum total of 4 arguments)
  3. Each argument has to be supported and explained, and/or given an example which shows why it's important
  4. Each individual argument has to be introduced by an appropriate linking word/phrase.
  5. All arguments have to be presented and explained in an objective and neutral way.

- Again, we'll get into more detail for this part next week. But these are 5 core rules that you should always remember when writing the body of a for-and-against essay.

Other General Rules

- LENGTH - To quote an old saying: „An essay should be like a skirt – long enough to cover the topic, but short enough to keep it interesting.” No-one is expecting you to write a doctoral disertation here, just to show that you can explain an argument. Typically high-school argumentative essays are supposed to be 200-250 words.

- STYLE – be on the N.O.S.E (Neutral, Objective, Succinct (or Simple), Effective).

The N.O.S.E

- **Neutral –** Use a neutral writing style. Avoid using informal language (for example, don't say „kids", say „children") and grammatical structures. Contractions are not strictly forbidden, but some should be avoided if at all possible (for example „hadn't", „must've", „You'll", etc.) It's not a big mistake if you DO use them, but with time try to phase them out.
- **Objective –** You can't show that you favour one side of the argument over the other in any way. This is something that students often have problems with, especially if the topic in question is something they feel very strongly about. There's nothing else to say here but: suck it up. Remember, just because you're writing about something you disagree with doesn't automatically mean that you agree with it.
- **Succinct/Simple –** Avoid wordiness (or tautology). It's typically used by students who fear that they will appear as less intelligent if they use everyday words, but then overcompensate and use a totally unnecessarily complex (or superfluous) word. You can use them sparingly, but avoid overloading your essay with them. A good rule of thumb is to *not use two words when one word will do.*
- **Effective –** Some students feel that if they overload their essays with 5 arguments for each side that then the reader will think they're really really smart. We won't. The only thing which will probably happen is that you'll run out of good arguments and use poor arguments which aren't really well explained in your essay. It's better to have fever arguments which are well explained and supported than a bunch of them which you won't cover well enough.